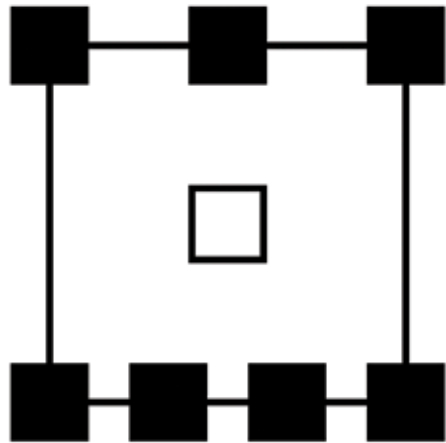


of two surround speakers on both sides, and a left, right and center speaker in front, along with the LFE channel. However, the presence of a smaller channel configuration is also supported, since many Dolby Digital decoders are equipped with downmixing to distribute encoded channels to speakers. This includes such functions as playing surround information through the front speakers if surround speakers are unavailable, and distributing the center channel to left and right if no center speaker is available.

The mostly recent innovation, that is also commercially supported, is the 7.1 sound configuration, a common name for an eight-channel surround audio system commonly used in home theatre configurations. It adds two additional speakers to the more conventional 5.1 audio configuration. While the standard front, center, and LFE (subwoofer) speaker configuration remains the same, a 7.1 surround system splits the surround and rear channel information into four distinct channels, in which sound effects are directed to left and right surround channels, plus two rear surround channels. However, audio technology doesn't yet encode audio for a 7.1 configuration; instead, it refers to the manufacturers' own systems used to derive two back surround channels from existing sources.



A 7.1 surround sound configuration, with the listener in the center

Whether you're looking to purchase a simple one speaker set, or an entire home theatre system, we're hoping this short primer will help you understand the specifications of your target product, and make an informed decision. **d**